Fierce Fairytales (Female Strength)

By Nakita Gill

Question the Fairytale (Pg 148)

What if Cinderella had an attitude problem
and Snow White just liked the idea
of strangers and poisons too much?

What if the Little Mermaid always enjoyed human
company
more than her own kind's and Sleeping Beauty
just liked her solitude more than human touch?

What if the only rabbit hole Alice ever fell down was
a terrible mistake with an awful substance,
never discussed as such?

What if they locked Wendy away
for hallucinating about Neverland
and a boy who never grew up?

What if fairytales aren't as innocent
as they sound and even princesses
aren't perfect?

What if I told you that your damage
doesn't define you and the way you survive
is no one else's damned business?

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INTRODUCTION

*Cinderella; Snow White; Sleeping Beauty and Wendy Moira Angela Darling. *snort in disdain* Traditional fairytales are rife with cliches and gender stereotypes. The heroines are beautiful, kind, helpful, compassionate . . .* ***helpless, naïve, submissive and weak****. It's time we moved these tales into the 21st century, where women are so much more. Women are powerful. Women are fierce.*

Today you'll hear the innermost thoughts of Pandora as she battles the evils of humanity; you'll be encouraged to find your voice by Poseidon's daughter Ariel; and you'll find your strength with Gretel; not Hansel and Gretel . . . just Gretel. Because women are so much more than fairytales make them out to be. Women are powerful. Women are fierce.

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The Moral of Your Story (Pg 117)

This is how they lie to us:
Love, love so selflessly
that you change the world.

The truth is brutal:
if you care this way
the world will gut you mercilessly.
And harsher still:
all of this love you hold
is ***too*** selfless.

Yes, my dear,
too selfless exists no matter
how much they deny it.

You see, you have been
taught to give too much
without wanting anything back.
What no one tells you
is this constant sacrifice
is designed to keep you pliant.

It is designed to keep you weak
and one day
it will devastate you.

And what good are you destroyed
to anyone, ***to anything***,
especially to your own truth?

Pandora's Mind (Pg 103)

Seeking the secret potion to happiness
inside the rooms of my mind may as well be
walking through all the chambers of Pandora's box.

In there, religion nodded knowingly,
'Confess every sin, all of them,
lay your heart before God, you will feel lighter.'
I tried it but I also kept sinning,
so the light never came —

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-- as my common sense pressed her fingertips together,
'Keep a journal and put all of your feelings
inside it,' and I made an effort, I really did,
but my feelings are so many that even
a hundred journals later I am not empty –

-- as social expectation interjected,
'What you need is a husband with strong hands
and he can take out all the sadness shelves
that are lined up inside your head.' But it doesn't know that
these shelves just build themselves back up –

-- as my depression politely informed me,
'No one is really going to love you,
you are too difficult to love anyway.'
And I tried and tried to make myself more loveable,
But in the process I just lost myself—

-- as my anxiety screamed in annoyance,
'Worry about other things like the moon moving farther
from the earth every year or your mother's heart or‘ And all
I know now is how to worry about
dead stars and money at the same time –

-- as social conditioning tried to educate me,
'Perhaps things like dreaming to be a writer
when you could do something sensible is the problem.' And
I tried my best to silence myself,
but my voice was too strong –

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-- yet a little voice inside me called Hope said softly,
'Millions of good people die unhappy every year,
not a single one of them is coming back
to give the world a chance to change
and deserve them.'

And it reminded, 'Maybe living your truth
may not make you happy all the time,
but it will make you happy every day.'

And it believed, 'Perhaps stand for
what you believe in, even if you are
the only one in the whole room.'

And it whispered, 'Perhaps the secret
to your own happiness lies inside
the owning of who you are, even broken.'

So I mixed the roots of hope
together inside an inkwell, filled a pen,
and finally wrote my truth.

An Older and Wiser Little Mermaid Speaks (Pg 81)

There are so many ways to lose a voice.
An uncomfortable laugh, don't make a scene
what will people say about you
what will people say about ***us***.

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I ask you now,
do women pray to softer-spoken gods than men do?
Do men pray louder and more
unapologetically than women ever have?

We are taught not to speak and if we do
be pliant, be passive, be soft, be sorry.
You are better as water anyway.
Water is supposed to simply adapt.

I ask you now, as the granddaughter of Poseidon
who gave up her fins and voice for love,
not to trade your magic in for anyone.
Do not make sacrifice the ritual of your womanhood.

I teach my half-sea girls that their voices
are the most powerful things they can use,
to let the word 'no' become the charm
they need to help them take up space often.

Now the mermaids are becoming sirens,
for sirens are monsters who never feel compelled and
monsters, unlike girls and mermaids,
know how to protect themselves well.

Gretel After Hansel (Pg 73)

Did anyone ever tell you what happens
if you kill a witch before you grow up?
That you leave a part of yourself in that storybook

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place,
saccharine sweet with bitter memories?
You are half fairytale, half girl,
with parents who chose to abandon you,
a brother who swore he would never leave
then found a wife and left you.
And here you are, picking yourself apart
breadcrumb by breadcrumb,
trying to learn how to swallow survival,
but a part of you never left the witch's door.
You still have the grit and determination
that stopped a child-eating monster
in her tracks; that wasn't Hansel, that was you.
And damaged though you are, that girl is still there.
Our stories don't begin and end
because men we once trusted have left them,
we were made whole to start with,
independent tales of strength and madness.
What I am trying to say is, Gretel,
you define yourself, without your brother;
you define yourself with your courage,
which was already imprinted on your bones.
No one taught you how to survive,
darling, you did that on your own.
Even without him, you can bring down monsters.
Believe me. You can still bring down monsters.

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Once Upon a Time II (Pg 4)

It is up to you to rise again
from the fragmented shards
your foes left of you.

You must lift a sword
with reborn strength and take on
the demons in your ribcage.

You must devastate the chains
every violent person
has brutally placed on you.

And you must show them all
how ***they*** were simply
characters in ***your*** story.

But you, you are the author
of this spellbinding tale
built of hope and bravery.

Out there may be monsters, my dear.
But in you still lives the dragon
you should always believe in.

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